

Eating Disorder Treatment at CCI

Cognitive Behaviour Therapy (CBT)

At CCI, we offer Cognitive Behavioural Therapy (CBT) – an **evidence-based treatment for eating disorders** that research has found to be effective. CBT understands that the way we **think** (cognitions) affects how we **feel** and **behave**. It focuses on what is going on in your life currently (the ‘here and now’) and helps you change the thoughts and behaviours that keep the eating disorder going.

What to expect from treatment

Treatment is collaborative and a team effort. You will be working towards recovery with a clinical psychologist who is specialised in eating disorder treatment. Your clinician will help you work out individual goals that are consistent with recovery from an eating disorder. Then, you’ll create a plan to help you reach those goals.

Your clinician will be here to listen, support you, and provide you with new information. They will help you learn how to identify behaviours, thoughts, and feelings that keep disordered eating going. They will introduce new strategies for you to practice both within sessions and outside of sessions. They will encourage you to take big steps and take on challenges in new ways.

Recovery from an eating disorder may feel tough at times. It takes effort, practice, and persistence – especially when things feel hard. Between sessions, you will be asked to try out new skills, keep track of your eating habits, and notice your thoughts and feelings.

Sometimes, your therapist will ask you to face things that feel scary or uncomfortable. While this may be challenging, this is a normal part of the process designed to help you become stronger and more confident in yourself, as well as providing valuable learning you will need for a full recovery.

Essential aspects of treatment

1) Weekly open weighing. Each week, you’ll be weighed openly in a supported way that is different to how you might have been weighed previously. This is to ensure your physical safety and gives you the chance to learn more about the relationship between your eating and the number on the scale.

2) Daily self-monitoring. Every day, you’ll be asked to record your eating patterns and associated thoughts and feelings in real time. This is an important part of treatment that will help you be more aware of what’s going on and give your therapist helpful information to guide your treatment. See our [Self-Monitoring](#) handout for further information.

3) Regular attendance. Coming to sessions regularly is one of the best ways to make progress and stay on track. Research shows that people who attend consistently have a better chance of recovering from their eating disorder.

4) Taking steps toward change. Recovery will involve making consistent changes to normalise your eating, working towards a stable weight that is right for your body, and facing fears about food and your body image. We want you to be an active participant in treatment. Research shows that the more actively you engage in your treatment, the better your chances of full recovery from your eating disorder.

5) Attending regular appointments with your doctor to monitor your physical health during treatment.

6) If your health deteriorates or treatment is not progressing in an outpatient setting, you may need to go to hospital or seek a higher level of support.

If this happens, your regular treatment will pause until you’re ready to return.

Structure of treatment

Treatment at CCI is time-limited and the length of treatment could be between 3 to 12 months. To get the most out of treatment, it is important to attend every **weekly** session, practice the skills between appointments, and complete the course of treatment.

Early phase of treatment

At the beginning, you and your therapist will focus on understanding what is keeping the eating disorder going. You will start making early changes, like eating regularly and reducing eating disordered behaviours. You will be weighed at each session and will begin recording your self-monitoring of your eating, thoughts, feelings, and behaviours. Early change is key for a good outcome!

Regular reviews

After about 5 sessions, you will have a review with your clinician to see how things are going. If there are any things getting in the way of change, you and your clinician will work together to address them. You will continue to have regular reviews throughout treatment to ensure you are making consistent progress.

Middle phases of treatment

We will begin to make more changes. This could include: reintroducing feared foods, addressing emotional triggers, and working towards body image acceptance. You may also work with your clinician on other issues that are relevant to your eating disorder, such as worry, perfectionism, low self-esteem, or managing your moods.

Ending phase of treatment

As you near the end of treatment, you will focus on how to maintain your progress and prevent relapse. CBT is designed to help you become your own therapist, so you can keep practicing the skills you have learned, even once treatment has finished. Your clinician may discuss follow-up sessions with you, to keep you on track in the months after treatment.